Sale was not planning to be so easily robbed: ‘My chest of drawers they took possession of with great glee – I left some rubbish in them, and some small bottles, that were useless to me. I hope the Afghans will try their contents as medicine, and find them efficacious; one bottle contained nitric acid, another a strong solution of lunar caustic.’[21]

Several days later the caravan containing the prisoners crossed with that taking the wounded Akbar Khan back to Kabul. George Lawrence saw him pass in his palanquin. ‘He looked pale and ill,’ he wrote,

> and he carried his wounded arm in a sling; he returned our salutations very courteously. He smiled as I passed him, and beckoning me to join him, spoke in a free and soldierly manner of Sale’s victory and his own defeat, praising the gallant bearing of our men, with Sale conspicuous on his white charger at their head. He admitted that his force had fled precipitately, he himself having to get out of his palanquin and escape on horseback. Had our troops only followed up a few miles further to the bank of the river, he must have been captured, as he had to remain some hours until a raft could be prepared to take him across.[22]

Waving goodbye, Akbar Khan headed on towards Kabul, while the prisoners were escorted by a different route to a fortress at the top of the Tezin Pass. On the road they crossed again the route of the January retreat, passing frequent macabre reminders of its horrors. ‘Many of the bodies, from being imbedded in the snow, were little altered, but most were reduced to skeletons,’ noted Lawrence.[23] More tragic still were the feral remains of the sepoy army, some of whom were still hiding out in the caves of the high passes. Lady Sale saw one cave in front of which lay a huge pile of human bones, ‘and from the blood close to its entrance, there is reason to believe that the inhabitants were supporting nature by devouring each other. I saw three spectral figures crawling on hands and knees just within the cave and heard them calling out for help as we passed.’[24]

The next few days of the hostages’ forced march took place in pouring rain and through thick mud. It was a particularly violent downpour near Sarobi that finally finished off the ailing General Elphinstone; as he had long predicted, he would never make it back to his beloved Borders grouse moors. Yet it was a measure of his personal charm that despite being almost single-handedly responsible for the catastrophe that had led to the prisoners’ current situation, he was faithfully tended by the other hostages to the end. Mackenzie and Lawrence were particularly solicitous and shared shifts with Moore, his batman, to look after the old General as he faded away, and, though without any medicine, Mackenzie ‘was able to sooth in some degree